

history view. Activate it by quickly swapping your finger in from outside the right-hand side of the screen, or tapping the icon that shows an arrow pointing toward left, next to the full-screen icon on the right bottom portion of the screen. History shows you all the pages you've visited in the past before striking on the current page. You swap your finger to the left to go back and open a page from history.

All in all, using this browser is a pleasant experience—who knew browsing on a mobile device could be so interactive? And thanks to the physical QWERTY keyboard—which although, needs a bit of getting used to—you actually feel that size doesn't really matter, that much.

Things multimedia

Let's start with the default media player (Figure 17). Now, I had a few songs on the microSD card I use in my LG phone. So, I hot-swapped it and launched the media player. To my surprise, it auto-detected all the songs. As expected, it's smart enough to understand ID3 tags and can categorise songs under albums, artists, or genres. Creating playlists is a no-brainer too. Besides, if the album art is inside the folder, the media player displays that too... in both the main media player (Figure 18), or the desktop widget. You can control the media playback using the desktop widget, too, and tapping the album-art area of the widget twice will launch the media player app for finer control.

The N900's stereo speakers have decent sound output, or you can use the headsets that come with the pack. The device is smart enough to maintain different volume levels between the headset and the device's stereo speakers. This is a nice feature considering, normally, you'll have the volume at max when using the speakers, while if you plug in the headset you'll probably go deaf at a full volume output. However, when you plug in the headset, the volume switches to a much lower level, and you can increase (or decrease) the level that's most comfortable to you.



Figure 17: The media player app



Figure 18: Playing a song



Figure 19: Exporting a photo to Facebook

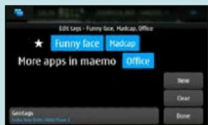


Figure 20: Tagging an image

Apart from the audio player, the media player is also home to Internet radio and videos. The radio has some preset stations—mostly European, I guess. But adding new stations is as easy as accessing the add radio bookmark button, entering the station's name and the m3u stream URL. So, within seconds I was happily enjoying RadioParadise—my favourite station.

Watching videos is a pleasure, thanks to the high resolution and the wide-screen display. I copied a DivX file and the playback seemed crisp. This makes it a handy device when you're travelling and want to catch up on a movie to kill time :-). Also, while viewing a video, right from within the player, you have the option to share the video—over Bluetooth, as a mail attachment or via an online service. The online services that you can use are Flickr, Facebook, and OVI. Setting up these accounts is a one-time business, and next time onwards sharing is as simple as a few taps. To check the feature I shot a video using the phone's camera, and soon I had that posted on my Facebook page. A conversation followed on my Facebook page, as people couldn't make anything of that video—it was shot in a hurry :-).

Talking about the camera, it's a 5 megapixels backed by a double-LED flash. The picture quality

is comparable to that of digital cameras—which makes the N900 one of the coolest GNU/Linux-powered one-size-fits-all device. Click a picture, geo tag it, and share it instantly using the online services, if you have some sort of connectivity.

Back to the media player—it would have been really handy if it integrated the picture viewer application too. Nonetheless, it's available as a separate application, and has a decent set of features. Opening it gives you access to all the pictures/screenshots inside the device, where ever they are located—its guesswork is intelligent enough, just like that of the media player's. Tapping an image opens it in full-screen mode, as expected. To browse your collection you can swap your finger right/left to view the next/previous image—or better, use the slideshow view. You can rotate the display to all the four sides of the screen by simply rotating the device. The accelerometer, however, didn't work while playing videos.

There are many other features, and you should explore them yourself to see the magic of Maemo's multimedia capabilities. The best part is it even comes with an FM transmitter—so you can broadcast what you're listening to. I couldn't test how it works in the short span of time I had.